
Ethnic tourism in
Chiangrai
Discover the Ethnic Cultures of Chiang Rai
TOURISM AUTHORITY OF THAILAND

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Discover the Ethnic Cultures of Chiang Rai



Chiang Rai is a destination of stories in the mountains, where nature, culture and people have lived in harmony for generations. Ethnic tourism is more than a journey to the highlands: it is an encounter with ways of life still deeply rooted in heritage, wisdom and the spirit of the community.

Chiang Rai is home to many ethnic groups, including the Akha, Karen, Lahu, Lisu, Lua, Hmong, Tai Lue, Tai Yai, Yao and Yunnanese. Each has a distinct identity expressed through language, dress, crafts, rituals, beliefs and ways of living in tune with the mountains, forests and seasons. Cultural tourism in these areas offers more than sightseeing. It invites visitors to learn and participate with respect and understanding.

Sitting together to embroider traditional patterns, discovering the meanings woven into textiles, cooking local dishes with community ingredients, or listening to elders' stories all reveal the value of ethnic wisdom, beautifully passed down through generations. These experiences leave lasting impressions while helping to conserve culture and generate sustainable income for local communities.

This e-book takes readers into the world of Chiang Rai's ethnic ways of life through stories, evocative images and cultural tourism activities that reflect the simple beauty of mountain communities. It invites us to open our minds, learn and respect cultural diversity as responsible visitors, and to help sustain these ethnic ways of life for the future.

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Akha

The Akha are an ethnic group who live in the high mountains of northern Thailand. In Chiang Rai, their communities are spread across Mae Fah Luang, Mae Chan, Mae Suai, Chiang Saen and Mae Sai districts, as well as Mueang Chiang Rai, Wiang Kaen, Doi Luang and others. Surrounded by abundant nature, they depend chiefly on tea plantations, coffee farms and fruit orchards.

History and culture

The Akha migrated from southern China and place great importance on traditions and community customs. Each village has a sacred spirit gate, called "Lo Kho," protecting it from evil and serving as a site for important annual rituals. Their beliefs in nature spirits reflect the close relationship between people and the natural world.

Traditional dress

Akha clothing is distinctive and also expresses social status.

• Women wear headdresses decorated with silver coins, beads and red tassels, symbolizing beauty and wealth. Black or dark-indigo tops carry red, white and blue geometric embroidery.

• Men wear black or indigo long-sleeved tops edged with bright red, blue or white fabric, with wide-legged trousers.

Local food

Akha cooking emphasizes herbs and wild vegetables, especially rak chu, a root with a distinctive aroma and spicy heat. Dishes include chicken soup with rak chu, stir-fried pork belly with rak chu, pickled rak chu, Akha cassia-leaf curry, herb-fried pork and eggplant chili dip. Akha tea, brewed from highland-grown leaves, is often served in bamboo cups.

Major festivals

• Swing Festival: Held in August-September to thank the goddess of fertility, with swinging, dancing and traditional games.

• Akha New Year: Celebrated in December to honor the harvest and seek blessings for the village's peace and well-being.

Wisdom and crafts

The Akha are known for embroidery, silverwork and bamboo weaving. Designs identify individual clans, with hook, spiral, floral and starlight motifs.

Where to experience the culture

@ Ban Pha Hi and Ban Pha Mi (Mae Sai): Sea-of-mist viewpoints, renowned Akha coffee and opportunities to learn about Akha food.

@ Ban Mae Chan Tai (Mae Suai): Cultural conservation tourism, homestays and activities exploring coffee and Akha life.

@ Ban Lo Yo and Ban Mae Rai Community (Mae Chan): Akha agritourism, food, language and rituals.

@ Ban Pa Kluai (Mae Fah Luang): Discover ways of life, traditions and beliefs conveyed through embroidered textiles.

@ Ban Doi Sa Ngo (Chiang Saen): Experience Akha life and food, and a viewpoint overlooking 3 countries.







Karen

The Karen, who call themselves "Pga K'nyau," are an ethnic group living in northern Thailand, including Chiang Rai, particularly Mae Fah Luang, Mae Chan, Mae Suai and Mae Sai districts. Their villages are usually on hillsides or in valleys beside streams or rivers, supporting sufficient and sustainable farming.

Way of life and beliefs

The Karen believe in nature spirits and respect mountains, water, forests and ancestors. Life is closely tied to nature. Rituals asking forgiveness of forests and water, thanking the rice, and making forest merit express respect and gratitude. They seek to live in balance with the forest, using resources in moderation and practicing crop rotation without harming the environment.

Traditional dress

Karen clothing is simple, beautiful and distinctive, with different styles for men and women.

• Unmarried women generally wear an entirely white handwoven dress, symbolizing purity.

• Married women wear bright tops, such as red or pink, decorated with silk tassels, Job's tears seeds and vertical woven patterns.

• Men often wear indigo or deep-red tops, loose traditional trousers and handwoven waist sashes.

Local food

Karen food is simple, using ingredients from forests and gardens: banana-blossom curry, boiled vegetables with chili dip, herb-grilled chicken, sticky rice and lightly milled rice. Flavors are not intensely spicy, emphasizing fragrant herbs and fresh ingredients.

Festivals and traditions

• Karen New Year: Around January, celebrating the harvest and thanking nature through dance, folk songs and instruments such as long drums.

• Rice Thanksgiving, or the new-rice offering: Honors the rice spirit that brings life and abundance to the community.

Wisdom and crafts

Karen textiles feature vertical patterns in white, red, blue and pink, conveying purity, courage and fertility. Cotton is commonly used, with natural dyes such as indigo and brown from tree bark. Weaving produces everyday necessities as well as art expressing women's status and beauty in the community.

Where to experience the culture

@ Ban Karen Ruam Mit and the Long-Neck Karen Village (Mueang Chiang Rai): Welcome visitors to experience traditional life, weaving, woodcarving and jewelry making.

@ Ban Huai Hin Lat Nai (Wiang Pa Pao): Learn sustainable farming, wild-tea harvesting and processing, and wild honey production.

@ Ban Huai Nam Khun (Mae Suai): Observe local life and join in preparing traditional food.



Lahu



The Lahu, known to Thai people as "Musoe," live in Chiang Rai's high mountains, including Mueang Chiang Rai, Mae Fah Luang, Mae Sai, Mae Chan and Wiang Kaen districts, and around Doi Mae Salong. The cool year-round climate suits tea, coffee and temperate vegetables.

History and culture

The Lahu originated in Yunnan, China, and migrated to Thailand around the early 20th century. "Lahu" means "fighter," reflecting courage and independence. They value sufficient living, respect nature and believe in supernatural beings, including spirits of the sky, earth, forests and mountains. A spiritual ritual leader called "Sa To," or shaman, mediates between people and nature spirits for the village's peace and well-being.

Traditional dress

Lahu clothing is simple yet beautiful and varies among groups such as the Black, Red and Yellow Lahu.

• Women wear black or dark-blue long-sleeved tops decorated with red, green and yellow fabric and geometric patterns, with finely embroidered head coverings or turbans.

• Men wear loose long-sleeved tops and trousers embroidered or trimmed in bright red, blue or green.

Local food

Lahu food is simple but rich in knowledge of forest herbs. Dishes include mixed-vegetable curry, herb-boiled pork, fermented-soybean chili dip, smoked meat, sticky rice mixed with salt, and Lahu tea from Doi Mae Salong. Most ingredients come from rotational fields and vegetables grown within the community.

Major festivals

• Kin Wo (Lahu New Year): Held from January to March after the harvest. Main activities include Ja Khu dancing around a fire, making khao puk rice cakes (O Phu), and pouring water over the village headman's hands as a gesture of respect.

• Village and household spirit festival: Dispels misfortune and asks ancestral spirits to bless the village with peace and happiness.

Wisdom and crafts

Lahu textiles feature vivid red, green, blue and yellow geometric patterns, using patchwork and hand embroidery to symbolize strength and abundance. They also produce finely crafted bamboo baskets and fishing tools.

Where to experience the culture

@ Ban Ja Lae (Mueang Chiang Rai): Trekking routes and activities introducing Lahu culture.

@ Ban Huai Nam Khun (Mae Suai): A tourism village conserving traditional Lahu life, and the Huai Nam Khun Royal Project Development Center.

@ Ban Khun Suai (Mae Suai): A popular place to learn about Lahu farming and everyday life amid mountain scenery.

@ Ban Ja Bu Si (Mae Fah Luang): Tea and coffee growing, with kitchen gardens supplying household food.



Lisu

The Lisu, also known as "Liso," live in Chiang Rai's high mountains in Mae Fah Luang, Mae Sai, Mae Chan, Phan, Wiang Pa Pao, Mae Suai and Chiang Khong districts, especially around Doi Mae Salong and Ban Huai Hom. Villages often stand along ridgelines, with rows of bamboo or log houses and a broad central space for communal activities.

History and culture

The Lisu originated in southern China (Yunnan) and migrated to northern Thailand around 100 years ago. "Lisu" means "the brave" or "the honorable," reflecting ethnic pride and inner strength. They honor ancestors and sacred natural beings, including forest, mountain and household spirits. Village-spirit worship, rain-seeking ceremonies and rituals for abundant crops are central to their lives.

Traditional dress

Lisu dress is among the most colorful and beautiful ethnic clothing in northern Thailand.

• Women wear bright pink, blue, green or purple long-sleeved tops, with contrasting fabric panels and geometric embroidery. Long skirts consist of several fabric layers and are decorated with beads or metal coins.

• Men wear round-necked long-sleeved tops and loose trousers, usually dark blue or black with bright trims.

Their clothing reflects joy, self-pride and the lively spirit of the Lisu people.

Local food

Lisu food is simple, using natural ingredients and produce from rotational fields: local-vegetable curry, herb-boiled pork, popcorn, smoked meat and fermented-soybean chili dip. Forest herbs and fresh vegetables feature strongly in clean, healthy meals.

Major festivals

• Lisu New Year Festival: In February or early March, with circle dancing, folk songs and instruments such as drums, long drums and bamboo flutes. The whole village gathers to celebrate and express gratitude to ancestors.

• Household-spirit worship: Seeks peace and happiness for families and the village.

Wisdom and crafts

Lisu embroidery and patchwork are renowned in the North, especially colorful fabrics sewn into geometric designs. Bead and silver-coin jewelry and bamboo weaving are also arts passed down through generations.

Where to experience the culture

@ Ban Doi Lan (Mae Suai): A Lisu village preserving traditional culture, with homestays and beautiful natural views.

@ Ban Liso Pang Kok (Phan): Learn about Lisu life, dress and traditional rituals.

@ Ban Pang Sa (Mae Chan): An important destination where Lisu communities live alongside and support other ethnic groups.

Lua



The Lua, also known as "Lawa," are an indigenous ethnic group of Lanna. Evidence shows their long-established presence in northern Thailand. In Chiang Rai today, they live in Mae Lao, Mae Suai and Mae Chan districts, often in valleys and near forests.

History and culture

The Lua live simply and depend sustainably on nature, rotating crops and using resources wisely. They believe in spirits and sacred beings, especially household and forest spirits that protect the community. Their culture emphasizes unity and mutual help, including collective rice harvesting and house building.

Traditional dress

Lua clothing is simple yet beautiful.

• Women wear dark-blue, indigo or black cotton tube skirts. The waistband generally has plain designs or fine red lines symbolizing strength. They wear dark long-sleeved tops and a head wrap or covering.

• Men wear plain dark clothes, loose traditional trousers and waist sashes, with handwoven shoulder cloths.

Local food

Lua cooking uses forest and farm ingredients: bamboo-shoot curry, herbal chili dip, sticky rice with salt, and pork or chicken slowly grilled over a gentle fire. Food is not intensely spicy, emphasizing fragrant herbs and natural flavors.

Festivals and rituals

• Household-spirit ceremony: Held annually to seek peace and happiness for families and the village.

• Forest-spirit thanksgiving: Asks for abundant wildlife and crops, expressing respectful coexistence with nature.

• Post-harvest merit-making: Expresses gratitude to the land and its produce.

Wisdom and crafts

The Lua are skilled at weaving bamboo baskets, carrying baskets and household tools, as well as plain, dark textiles that express calm and stability. Most textile patterns are simple, embodying a philosophy of moderation.

Where to experience the culture

@ Ban Huai Nam Khun and Ban Pang Phraratchathan (Mae Fah Luang): Observe village-spirit offerings and rotational farming.

@ Ban Lua Phatthana (Mae Chan): Learn about Lua life, basketry and sufficient farming.

@ Ban Doi Chang (Mae Suai): Explore the culture, coexistence with forests and Arabica coffee growing.





Hmong

The Hmong are one of northern Thailand's largest ethnic populations. In Chiang Rai, they live in highland areas of Mae Fah Luang, Mae Suai, Mae Sai, Thoeng, Wiang Kaen, Chiang Khong and Wiang Pa Pao districts. Villages often occupy mountain summits or steep slopes suited to farming and a cool year-round climate.

History and origins

The Hmong originated in southern China around Yunnan and migrated south to Laos, Vietnam and northern Thailand some 100-150 years ago. There are 2 main groups:

• White Hmong: Traditionally favor white clothing.

• Black Hmong: Wear dark-blue or black clothing.

Way of life

The Hmong are hardworking farmers, especially of temperate vegetables, maize and tea. They are also skilled in embroidery, patchwork and weaving intricate, beautiful designs. Family, unity and respect for elders are central to everyday life.

Beliefs and rituals

The Hmong believe in spirits and ancestors, particularly household and ancestral spirits thought to protect family members. Important rituals include Hmong New Year, soul-calling ceremonies, weddings and funerals.

Traditional dress

Hmong dress is among the most distinctive and beautiful of northern ethnic clothing.

• Women wear black or dark-indigo long-sleeved tops with vivid embroidery and silver buttons. Broad pleated skirts feature bright embroidered and patchwork panels in pink, green, red and blue. Silver neck and head ornaments are worn at major festivals.

• Men wear black or dark-indigo long-sleeved tops, wide-legged trousers and red or blue waist sashes.

Local food

Hmong cooking is simple and uses natural ingredients: sticky rice, herb-stewed pork, mustard-green curry and grilled meat. Local herbs and spices, including ginger and lemongrass, are widely used.

Major festivals

• Hmong New Year: A major annual celebration around January, with dancing, ball-tossing games and traditional dress.

• Household-spirit feast: Thanks ancestral spirits and seeks blessings for the family's peace and happiness.

Wisdom and crafts

Hand embroidery and patchwork are characteristic Hmong arts. Textile designs draw on flowers, mountains and symbols of good fortune. The Hmong also excel at knife forging, silverwork and bamboo weaving.

Where to experience the culture

Places to encounter Hmong life include:

@ Ban Huai Han (Wiang Kaen): Experience traditional life, community activities and local wisdom.

@ Ban Hmong Kao Lang (Mae Fah Luang): New Year celebrations usually run from late December to early January, with cultural performances, contests, games and Hmong ways of life.

@ Ban Hmong Kio Kan and Ban Thung Na Noi (Chiang Khong): Stay amid nature, visit Hmong villages, and learn wax-resist drawing and traditional ways of life.



Tai Lue



The Tai Lue originated in Sipsong Panna, Yunnan, China, and migrated to northern Thailand several centuries ago. In Chiang Rai, their principal settlements are in Chiang Khong, Phaya Mengrai and Thoeng districts.

History and origins

The Tai Lue are closely related to the Tai Yai and Tai Lanna. Their spoken language and culture resemble those of Lanna people, yet they retain a clear identity of their own. They have deep Buddhist faith and lead peaceful, simple lives.

Way of life

Most Tai Lue people farm rice and cotton and raise livestock. Their distinctive raised wooden houses have wooden-shingle roofs. Inside are a Buddhist shrine room and a reception area, expressing the community's faith and warmth.

Beliefs and traditions

Tai Lue beliefs combine Buddhism with older traditions, including respect for ancestral, household, forest and mountain spirits.

Festivals and rituals

• Tai Lue New Year: Similar to Songkran, with merit-making, alms-giving, bathing Buddha images and pouring water over elders' hands in respect.

• Bun Khao Pradap Din: Merit-making dedicated to ancestors.

• Pha Pa offerings and Buddhist Lent: Express devotion to Buddhism.

Traditional dress

Tai Lue clothing is beautiful and distinctive.

• Women wear handwoven tube skirts with khit or chok patterns in indigo, blue, red or pale pink, black or dark-indigo round-necked long-sleeved tops, and bright head wraps.

• Men wear mo hom indigo tops, traditional sado trousers and waist sashes, sometimes adding head wraps for merit-making events.

Local food

Tai Lue food has gentle flavors and is not intensely spicy. Natural ingredients feature in Tai Lue khao soi noodles, mustard-green curry with dried fish, eggplant chili dip and khao chi, sticky rice grilled over charcoal.

Wisdom, arts and crafts

The Tai Lue are famed for weaving, especially delicate khit and chok textiles. Designs often draw on flowers, birds and geometric forms. Their textiles serve as everyday necessities and culturally meaningful souvenirs.

Where to experience the culture

@ Ban Si Don Chai (Chiang Khong): A Tai Lue textile learning center, with indigo-dyeing and weaving demonstrations in a village preserving traditional life.

@ Ban Hat Bai and Ban Huai Meng (Chiang Khong): Discover Tai Lue life beside the Mekong, cruise past river scenery and communities on both banks, and enjoy beautiful simplicity and local food that tells the community's story.



Tai Yai

The Tai Yai originate from Shan State in northern Myanmar. Their culture harmoniously blends Burmese and Lanna influences. In Chiang Rai, substantial communities live in Mueang Chiang Rai, Mae Chan, Mae Fah Luang and Mae Sai districts, particularly along the Thai-Myanmar border.

History and origins

The Tai Yai are a Tai ethnic group who migrated into Lanna many centuries ago. They speak their own language, Shan, and use a script resembling Burmese. They are deeply connected to Buddhism and have distinctive temples, including Burmese-style buildings and carved wooden temples.

Way of life

Most farm upland rice, tea, coffee and temperate crops, and trade at border markets. Life is simple, with a strong sense of community and mutual support.

Beliefs and traditions

Tai Yai practice Theravada Buddhism alongside beliefs in household spirits. Major traditions include:

• Poi Sang Long: A novice ordination ceremony for boys, dressed in beautiful bright silks and carried in musical processions around the village.

• Poi Khao Sang: Offering food to monks, symbolizing community unity.

• Buddhist Lent and its conclusion: Celebrated with candle processions, lantern lighting, merit-making and alms-giving.

Traditional dress

• Women wear long, horizontally patterned tube skirts, fitted long-sleeved tops and bright red, yellow or pink head wraps, often with silver jewelry.

• Men wear long trousers, head wraps and white or cream cotton shirts.

Local food

Tai Yai cuisine is strongly flavored but not very spicy, with fragrant herbs. Dishes include khao raem fuen, khao soi nam ngiao, hang le curry, fermented soybean sheets (thua nao phaen) and yardlong-bean salad. These foods reflect preservation knowledge and a blend of Lanna and Burmese flavors.

Wisdom, arts and crafts

The Tai Yai excel at weaving silk and cotton with floral or horizontal patterns. Gold, brown and red convey warmth and prosperity. Fine woodcarving, silverwork and lacquerware are also characteristic crafts.

Where to experience the culture

@ Wat Huai Pla Kang (Mueang Chiang Rai): A local Tai Yai community participates in Buddhist activities where visitors can encounter traditional merit-making.

@ Wat San Pa Ko Tai Yai (Mueang Chiang Rai): A beautiful temple with a distinctly Tai Yai identity.

@ Ban Thoet Thai (Mae Fah Luang): A community preserving traditional culture, with local markets and Tai Yai restaurants.

Yao / Mien



The Yao, who call themselves "Mien," are one of Chiang Rai's main ethnic groups. They live across Mae Fah Luang, Chiang Saen and Wiang Pa Pao districts. Villages are often in high mountains near watershed forests, supporting rotational farming and a balance with nature.

History and origins

The Yao originated in southern China and migrated south through Laos and Vietnam, reaching Thailand around the late 19th century. They have a clearly defined clan and kinship system and have firmly preserved their language, culture and ancient Chinese writing.

Way of life

Agriculture is their main occupation, including upland rice, maize, tea and herbs. Some communities process tea and traditional herbs for sale as community products. The Yao value hard work, thrift and their children's education.

Beliefs and religion

The Yao believe in ancestral and nature spirits and Taoist deities, particularly "Luang Pu Sae" (or Pu Yao), the group's spiritual guide. Religious ceremonies include setting up ancestral shrines (Pang Cheng), clan-spirit worship, and the Mien Lent ceremony (Yao New Year), held in December or early January.

Traditional dress

• Women wear dark-blue or black cotton clothes embroidered with bright thread, distinguished by a vivid red chest cloth. Silver necklaces, bracelets and earrings complete the dress.

• Men wear dark trousers, plain long-sleeved cotton tops and small head wraps.

Local food

Yao food tends toward salty and slightly sour flavors, using forest ingredients such as mushrooms, bamboo shoots, tea leaves and herbs. Local dishes include pork and bamboo-shoot curry, Yao sun-dried meat, sticky rice wrapped in banana leaves, and boiled herbal tea for health.

Culture, arts and crafts

Embroidery is a highlight, using red, yellow, blue and pink threads for geometric and floral patterns. These designs express beliefs in abundance and life force. The Yao are also skilled in Chinese calligraphy and ancient rituals passed down through generations.

Major festivals and traditions

• Yao New Year: Ancestral offerings, dancing, drum music and cultural performances.

• Yao weddings: Ceremonial presentation of wedding gifts and ancient Chinese chanting.

• Yao ordination: A consecration ceremony recognizing young men as adults of the community.

Where to experience the culture

@ Ban Huai Han (Mae Salong Nok): A Yao village welcoming visitors to observe life, see embroidery and taste Yao tea.

@ Ban Santi Khiri (Doi Mae Salong): Blended Yao-Chinese culture, tea markets and local food.

@ Ban Huai Kwan (Chiang Saen): A long-established community that fully preserves its Yao language and rituals.

Yunnan



Most Yunnanese people in Chiang Rai are Chinese Ho descendants and Yunnanese Chinese associated with the Kuomintang, whose migrant generation arrived during the Chinese Civil War before 1960 (B.E. 2503). They now live in the highlands of Mae Fah Luang, Mae Chan and Mae Sai districts and Doi Mae Salong, nationally renowned for tea, food and traditional Yunnanese Chinese culture.

History and origins

Many Yunnanese settled in Thailand after the war with the Chinese Communists, particularly the Kuomintang's 93rd Division, which settled at Doi Mae Salong, now Mae Salong Nai Subdistrict, Mae Fah Luang. The settlement grew into today's Ban Santi Khiri. Yunnanese people in Chiang Rai now harmoniously combine Han-Yunnanese Chinese culture with northern Thai life.

Way of life

Areas with substantial Yunnanese communities include:

• Doi Mae Salong (Santi Khiri): Thailand's most important oolong tea production area.

• Mae Fah Luang: Traditional Chinese communities scattered among highland villages.

• Mae Sai and Mae Chan: Linked to Thai-Myanmar border trade.

• Chiang Saen and Chiang Khong: Home to long-established Chinese Ho communities and Yunnanese traders.

Culture and daily life

They speak Yunnanese Chinese in Kunming or Ho dialects. Younger generations often also use northern Thai and central Thai.

Traditional dress

• Traditional Yunnanese Chinese clothing includes velvet tops and Chinese fabric-knot buttons.

• Traditional Chinese outfits, such as velvet waistcoats and embroidered fabrics, are still worn at festivals.

Local food

Distinctive cuisine has become a major tourism attraction: pork knuckle with mantou buns, Yunnanese khao soi, black chicken stewed with Chinese herbs, thousand-year pork, Yunnanese braised eggs, and oolong, green and black teas from Doi Mae Salong. Drinks and tea are important Yunnanese heritage. Highland tea growing is a cultural strength of Doi Mae Salong, especially oolong No. 12 and No. 17. Visitors can walk through plantations, taste tea and learn its production process.

Culture, arts and crafts

Chinese floral embroidery, pottery, Chinese-pattern woodcarving, performances such as Chinese martial arts, fan and sword dances, and Chinese ceremonial tea preparation.

Major festivals and traditions

• Chinese New Year: Firecrackers, food offerings and incense worship.

• Vegetarian Festival: Reflects Taoist and Chinese Buddhist beliefs.

• Mid-Autumn Festival: Mooncake making and village festivities.

• Tea Tasting and Wild Himalayan Cherry Blossom Festival (Doi Mae Salong): Attracts Thai and international visitors.

Where to experience the culture

@ Doi Mae Salong is a major cultural tourism landmark. The Yunnanese economy includes tea and coffee farming, community tourism, Yunnanese restaurants, Chinese goods and souvenir markets, and highland crops such as plums, peaches and strawberries.



Tai Ya

The Tai Ya speak "Tai Ya," a Tai-family language with sounds and vocabulary similar to Tai Lue and Tai Nuea. Younger generations speak northern Thai and central Thai well, using the languages side by side in daily life. Chiang Rai's Tai Ya communities are in Mae Sai, Mae Chan and Mae Fah Luang districts and still clearly preserve their language, dress and traditions.

History and origins

The Tai Ya (also called Tai Yo or Tai Ya in Thai) are a Tai ethnic group originating in Yunnan, southern China. They migrated to the upper Mekong basin and spread into northern Thailand, particularly Chiang Rai.

Way of life

Tai Ya people in Chiang Rai practice highland farming, growing upland rice, tea, coffee, vegetables and herbs. Some villages continue weaving, embroidery and reed-mat making across generations. Cultural groups also organize dancing, traditional games and annual rituals.

Traditional dress

Black is the characteristic color. Men and women commonly wear handwoven black tops with dark trousers or tube skirts. Women favor bright embroidery on the chest or sleeves and distinctive black head wraps.

• Women wear 2 layered black tube skirts, decorated with colored strips sewn around the hem, with one edge hanging lower. Silver beads form patterns along the blouse hem and cuffs. A round cloth cap sits on the crown of the head.

• Men wear black or indigo loose traditional trousers and matching tops, with red or blue fabric bands at the cuffs.

Local food

Tai Ya food is simple, emphasizing local vegetables, pork and chicken. Key dishes include local-vegetable curry, herb-roasted pork, sticky rice steamed in banana leaves and Tai Ya pounded chili dip.

Culture, arts and crafts

Distinctive traditions include folk songs recounting ancestral stories, folk dance and music, reverence for ancestral and nature spirits (household and forest spirits), rituals blending traditional beliefs with Christianity, and inherited crafts such as weaving and reed-mat making.

Major festivals and traditions

• Tai Ya New Year: Folk dancing and communal feasting.

• Important Christian festivals (Christmas and Easter) and ancestral-spirit offerings, including cleaning cemeteries before Easter and honoring ancestral spirits.

Where to experience the culture

@ Ban Nam Bo Khao and Ban San That (Mae Sai): Tai Ya communities preserving traditional customs and culture, including dress and distinctive dance.

Ethnic tourism in Chiangrai



Cultural Tourism Map Chiang Rai

Akha
1. Ban Lo Yo (Mae Chan)
2. Ban Mae Rai Community (Mae Chan)
3. Ban Pha Hi (Mae Sai)
4. Ban Pha Mi (Mae Sai)
5. Ban Pa Kluai (Mae Fah Luang)
6. Ban Mae Chan Tai (Mae Suai)
7. Ban Doi Sa Ngo (Chiang Saen)

Karen / Pga K'nyau
8. Ban Karen Ruam Mit (Mueang Chiang Rai)
9. Long-Neck Karen Village (Mueang Chiang Rai)
10. Ban Huai Hin Lat Nai (Wiang Pa Pao)
11. Ban Huai Nam Khun (Mae Suai)

Lahu / Musoe
12. Ban Ja Lae (Mueang Chiang Rai)
13. Ban Huai Nam Khun (Mae Suai)
14. Ban Khun Suai (Mae Suai)
15. Ban Ja Bu Si (Mae Fah Luang)

Lisu / Liso
16. Ban Doi Lan (Mae Suai)
17. Ban Liso Pang Kok (Phan)
18. Ban Pang Sa (Mae Chan)

Lua
19. Ban Huai Nam Khun (Mae Fah Luang)
20. Ban Pang Phraratchathan (Mae Fah Luang)
21. Ban Lua Phatthana (Mae Chan)
22. Ban Doi Chang (Mae Suai)

Hmong
23. Ban Huai Han (Wiang Kaen)
24. Ban Hmong Kao Lang (Mae Fah Luang)
25. Ban Hmong Kio Kan (Chiang Khong)
25. Ban Thung Na Noi (Chiang Khong)

Tai Lue
26. Ban Si Don Chai (Chiang Khong)
27. Ban Hat Bai (Chiang Khong)
28. Ban Huai Meng (Chiang Khong)

Tai Yai
29. Wat Huai Pla Kang (Mueang Chiang Rai)
30. Wat San Pa Ko Tai Yai (Mueang Chiang Rai)
31. Ban Thoet Thai (Mae Fah Luang)

Yao
32. Ban Huai Han (Mae Fah Luang)
33. Ban Santi Khiri (Mae Fah Luang)
34. Ban Huai Kwan (Chiang Saen)

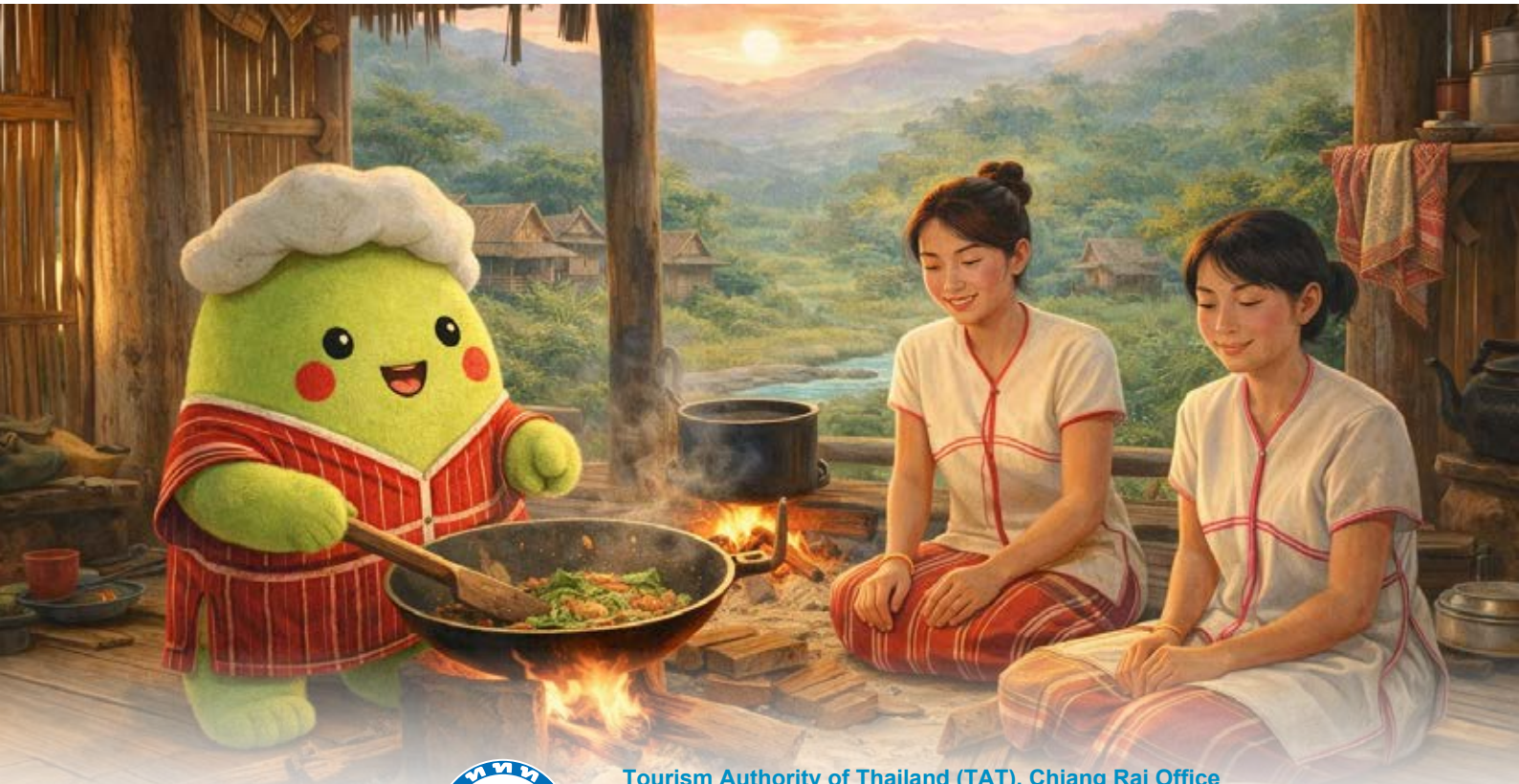
Yunnan
35. Doi Mae Salong (Mae Fah Luang)

Tai Ya
36. Ban Nam Bo Khao (Mae Sai)
37. Ban San That (Mae Sai)







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